

Replication Debate Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 35-45 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	replication-debate

Big idea: Human science knowledge is context-sensitive.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Replication Debate Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Replication Debate Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A headline claim, a replication attempt, and a contested interpretation. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Replication Debate Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Role cards for original researcher, replicator, journalist, and funding body. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Replication Debate Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A reliability scale separating failure, boundary condition, and fraud. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Human science knowledge is context-sensitive.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Replication Debate Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Replication Debate Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Does failed replication destroy knowledge?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A headline claim, a replication attempt, and a contested interpretation.
- Role cards for original researcher, replicator, journalist, and funding body.
- A reliability scale separating failure, boundary condition, and fraud.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Activity Steps

1. Give students a short description of the claim.
2. Groups design a replication study.
3. They must state sample, procedure, outcome measure, possible confounds and what would count as a failure.
4. Debate whether one failed replication should change belief.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Does failed replication destroy knowledge?
- Why are humans difficult to study?
- What makes evidence strong in psychology or economics?

Knowledge Questions

- Does failed replication destroy knowledge?
- Why are humans difficult to study?
- What makes evidence strong in psychology or economics?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a headline claim, a replication attempt, and a contested interpretation. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...